

of this sequel is the map editor which gives you the same tools as developers to create the maps and stories that unfold within them. If you're a fan of myth, magic or plain old tactical combat, *AoW II* will definitely have something for you to chew on.

Genre: *Real-time Strategy*

Developer: *Microsoft*

Estimated release date: *Second quarter of 2002*

COUNTER-STRIKE: CONDITION ZERO

After dominating multiplayer gaming for the last couple of years, *Counter-Strike* advances to the desktop—reason enough to cheer for anyone deprived of the thrills of counter-terrorist action against bots and human adversaries.

A robust single-player campaign, improved *Half-Life* graphics engine, superb AI programming and a slew of new weapons make *Counter-Strike: Condition Zero* truly worth the wait. You start as a lowly foot soldier fighting your way through military jungle camps and moving up in the ranks as you bag more and more successful missions.

Just to make life interesting, the game lacks a 'save game' feature, which will make completing each level a real challenge.

Keep your sniper ready for this one.

Genre: *Tactical Action FPS*

DUKE NUKEM FOREVER

3D Realms hopes to bring the original mean-mouth of PC gaming back to life. Last seen in action during the third chapter of the *Duke* series about six years ago, Duke will take on an old foe in Dr Proton, a cyborg who made an appearance in the first *Duke Nukem* title.

Wondering when it's expected? The official stand on an expected release date has been the same for the last couple of years, during which it moved from using a *Quake II* engine to a more advanced *Unreal*-based graphics engine.

While many feel that the game is vaporware, having already taken 'forever' to make an appearance, Duke, who is one of the original icons of action gaming, never seems to go out of fashion. Duke is forever!

Genre: *FPS/Action*

Developer: *3D Realms*

Estimated release date: *Whenever it's ready*

GRAND THEFT AUTO III

Driving, adventure and a heavy dose of violence and gore come together, perfectly balanced for your hidden, menacing side.



Developer: *Gearbox Software*

Estimated release date: *Third quarter of 2002*

DOOM III

Revisit the sinister and scary, dark and shadowy world that *Doom* unleashed on PCs back in 1995. The single most anticipated game in the foreseeable future comes from the demigods of game development—id Software. New game code builds on the strengths of the OpenGL-based *Quake III* engine and will bring the current generation of gaming hardware (yes, even the GeForce3!) to its knees. Legend has it that the game is being built on prototype graphics hardware running on massive server farms just to emulate the new game engine.

Expect lifelike characters that have never been seen before, as well as gripping single-player missions that have been noticeably absent from the recent id titles.

Cross your fingers and hope that *Doom III* is out by the end of 2002.

Genre: *FPS/Action*

Developer: *id Software*

Estimated release date: *End 2002*

With its unique perspective, *Grand Theft Auto III* (GTA III) puts you right in the middle of harm's way while you peddle drugs and kidnap your way to mo' money. The blatantly offensive title has taken a huge step by offering a fully 3D street experience to become one of the best action games yet to arrive for the PC platform. Another first-time highlight in this 'three-quel' is a fast-paced story line with the twists and turns you'd expect from a Pacino flick. The game is expansive; you can spend hundreds of hours roaming the streets and not know where time went. With *GTA III*, you don't have to worry about wetting your pants after getting busted for a hit!

Genre: *Arcade/Racing*

Developer: *Rockstar*

Estimated release date: *September 2002*

HALO

Released on the Xbox last year, *Halo* will cross over to the PC in 2002. This action-adventure title allows players to switch between first-person and third-person perspectives.

You play the part of a cybernetically enhanced commando who is trying to protect the earth from a rampaging alien race called the Covenant. A sci-fi shooter that takes place on a mysterious alien ring-world, *Halo* will have you battling through

